larger issues of banking system efficiency should have made it to the commentary.

Metaphors and Humour

I quickly learnt a few other things. The use of metaphors and humour often helped in making a point or evading a tricky question. In the summer of 2010, we were all in Thiruvananthapuram for the RBI Board meeting. Because of the drought in the previous year, there was nationwide anxiety about how the monsoon might turn out that year. This was also the time when we, in the Reserve Bank, were engaged in exiting from the accommodative policies of the crisis period which acquired additional urgency in view of inflation picking up momentum. Adjusting interest rates to subdue inflation and stimulate growth can be a tough job at the best of times but can get much tougher when the monsoon—some 60 per cent of India's farms are rain-fed—fails.

In the media interaction following the board meeting, there was the inevitable question about whether the Reserve Bank would tweak its 'exit path' in view of the monsoon prospects. Instinctively, what came to my mind was a book I had read several years ago—*Chasing the Monsoon* by Alexander Frater—a fascinating account of the New Zealander's journey across the Indian subcontinent in pursuit of the monsoon. Frater's romantic adventure, quite expectedly, starts in Thiruvananthapuram, where we then were. In answer to the question on the monetary policy stance, I replied that like millions of farmers across the country, we in the Reserve Bank too were chasing the monsoon. The media decided that I had answered their question. Perhaps they liked the imagery of the RBI governor sitting alongside farmers under a village tree, looking skywards for guidance on the interest rate policy. Here is a citation from a feature story, 'RBI's Subbarao Chases Monsoon', in the online edition of the *Wall Street Journal*:

> All RBI governors face this problem [of inflation caused by rising food prices on account of weak rainfall]. But it has a special resonance for Mr. Subbarao, as he discussed with reporters last week . . .